



**BJP LEADERS AFTER PETITIONING
MANMOHAN SINGH AGAINST PRICE RISE.**

quintal to Rs 1,030 and that of wheat from Rs 620 to Rs 1,100. This has pushed the prices of rice from Rs 13 to Rs 23 per kg, wheat from Rs 8 to Rs 14.5 and the food subsidy bill from Rs 25,000 crore a year to a budgeted Rs 60,000 crore, which is estimated to cross Rs 90,000 crore this year. Pawar, never shy of calling a spade a spade, declared that if higher prices have benefited farmers, he was guilty. "Why should farmers be expected to subsidise society?" he asks.

And there is no political risk here either. Politics operates on the unstated construct or covenant of aligning party interest to the votebank. And the existence of a public distribution system (PDS) that promises highly subsidised grains and some essentials to the poorest is the insurance. The premise is that farmers and the poorest of the poor constituting over two-thirds of the voters are being taken care of. This truth, in true Hindu tradition, has many versions. And even though procurement

Why CONGRESS Loves to Hate Pawar

No Maratha has ever ruled Delhi, this is what late Chandra Shekhar told Sharad Pawar. Yet, Pawar still hopes to break this historic tradition. That is the main reason why the Congress fears the grand Maratha, even when his strength in the Lok Sabha has been reduced to a mere nine MPs. The Congress is all too aware of the fact that Pawar's greatest strength is his ability to sway political opinions across party lines. In August 2008 when some enthusiastic Congressmen suggested Rahul Gandhi's name for prime minister, it was Pawar who said that it was "too early for Rahul". And that his candidate was Manmohan Singh. Other UPA constituents followed suit immediately. Moreover, he also determines who rules Maharashtra. For all its bravado about going it alone during the 2009 assembly polls, the Congress finally tied up with the NCP because it knows it cannot form a government in the state without Pawar.

No one plays politics better than this former Congressman who has worked with Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi. He is also the master of political nuance, giving back as good as he gets. Tired of the Congress sniping away at him on the price rise, he retorted that the blame was not his alone. He was guided by the prime minister and the Cabinet. Realising that he would not go down alone, the Congress immediately toned down the attack. Spokesman Shakeel

Ahmed said, "Pawar had simply stated the constitutional position. Checking prices is the collective responsibility of the Government." Message delivered, Pawar said his remarks had been taken out of context.

He is also one of the few Congressmen who has left the party and survived. Mamata Banerjee is another but, unlike Pawar, her politics is limited to West Bengal. Unlike the girlish Banerjee, the taciturn Pawar has not bothered to engage Sonia in small talk, preferring instead to depute the more urbane Praful Patel as his emissary to 10 Janpath. Never one to forget a slight, Sonia is still to trust the man who has left the Congress twice. Which is why the Congress-NCP relationship is one of the rockiest in the UPA. It is also the most enduring. Because the prime minister is equally aware of the fact that when it comes to the crunch—whether it is the nuclear deal or placating other UPA allies—he can count on Pawar.

by Priya Sahgal



SONIA GANDHI AND SHARAD PAWAR

HARYANA
**Bhupinder
Singh
Hooda**



WHO IS TO BLAME

"Various factors, from global prices to supply shortage to changes in eating habits."

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

"The UPA Government must have a common law on storage limits to curb hoarding."